

THE SHORT LEDGER

Fourth Wall Gaming

PRELUDE

Purewater is built on water and is entirely unembarrassed about it.

There is no ground. There are buildings, and there is water, and between them there are ledges a yard wide with no rail and a drop into a channel that has been carrying the city's traffic, its cargo, its gossip and its dead since before anybody kept a record. Houses come straight up out of it. Doors open onto steps that go down under the surface and keep going. Everything that matters travels by flat-bottomed boat, poled and rowed and shouted at, and every single journey costs a fare.

Anybody raised there can handle a boat. It is like walking, and nobody remarks on it, and no child has ever been praised for it.

The other half of that — the half nobody in Purewater ever bothers to say out loud, because saying it would be like announcing that water is wet — is that nobody *else* can. A stranger in that city cannot move a sack of flour across it, cannot get to the temple, cannot send a message, cannot flee, without hiring somebody who was born there.

There are no horses either. The land stops at Caravan Square and does not resume. A column coming down the Anminster road arrives at the gate and then has to be taken to pieces and put into boats in public, slowly, in front of everybody, one crate at a time, which is the most exposed a great house ever gets and the reason great houses hate the place.

Once there were Dragon Kings. They are gone and every child knows it. What is left of them is old armour on border lords, a name on a barony, and a small number of men who would like the old power back badly enough to pay whatever it costs and to let somebody else pay most of it.

The Lake Lady's Tourney comes round once a year — archery, single combat, and a scramble across the canals — and it is older than the Governor's office, and for the week of it the city fills up and the law goes quiet and everybody makes a year's money in six days.

This year Baron Hanzo di Teufel came down the road for it, with Dragon Knights at his back and a champion nobody had been permitted to see.

None of that is what this book is about.

This book is about a half-orc who collected debts on the Shoals bridges, and who found three accounts short in one week for the same reason, and who — because nobody had ever asked her opinion about anything in her entire life, and she had one — went and had a look.

CHAPTER 1 — THE SHORT LEDGER



KAG HAD WALKED THE SHOALS BRIDGES ON THE THIRD MORNING OF EVERY WEEK FOR NINE YEARS, north to south, before the catch was sorted and while the money was still loose on the trestles, and in all that time not one person on those bridges had ever asked her opinion about anything. They asked her to move a barrel. They asked her, once, memorably, to frighten a man's brother-in-law, and she had done it by standing quietly in a doorway for about ninety seconds. They asked her for the time, because she was tall enough to see the temple clock over the roofline, and they asked her whether it was going to rain, because she was out in it more than they were.

Nobody had ever asked her what a thing cost.

She was seven feet of half-orc in oiled leather with a club on her belt that she actually used, and the whole fish market moved around her without being asked to, and she had a quarter-bound octavo in her coat with five years of the Shoals written into it in her own hand. She had paid for the book herself. That was the part she'd never said out loud to anybody, and she didn't know why it mattered, and it did.

The rope stall was eleven shillings short.

"I'll have it Thursday," Dess said, and he wouldn't look up from the coil he was winding, and Dess had never been short in four years.

"You'll have it Thursday."

"I will."

She wrote the eleven and she wrote *Thursday* beside it and she went on down the bridge, and the ice woman was six shillings short, and two pitches along from her the man who dealt in cheap brass was nine.

Kag stopped in the middle of the bridge and got the book out again and stood there with the tide going out under her.

Three in a row was not three people stealing. Three people stealing did not steal in a line.

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The ice woman's boy wasn't there. That was the first thread, and she pulled it, and the whole thing came off the reel in about four minutes the way a bad knot does once you find the right end.

"They took the barrow," the woman said, and then looked at her hands, which is what people in that city did instead of crying in public. "Two of them, Monday. Wanted the ice for the horses and took the barrow to carry it and never brought the barrow back."

"Did they pay?"

"They don't pay."

"Did they leave you a chit?"

"There's no chit." The woman laughed at her, not unkindly, the way you laugh at a child asking where the moon goes. "There's nobody to give a chit. You go on down there and ask them for a chit, love, and let me know how you get on."

Dess had lost sixty feet of his best line off the end of the rack, four of them, Monday, no hurry about it. The brass man had lost nothing at all — he'd simply not been paid by three customers who had themselves not been paid, and that was the bit that made Kag's stomach go cold, because that was the thing spreading sideways.

She sat down on the dry stone at the south end with her knees up and did the arithmetic properly.

Twenty-six shillings off one bridge in one week. Nine bridges on the Shoals and eleven on the Lullwater, and she had walked every one of them for nine years and knew what each of them paid in an ordinary month the way a farmer knows a field.

Eleven pounds by Michaelmas. More than that, in fact, and this was the part nobody upstairs was going to understand without being shown it: a man who cannot pay stops asking for credit, and a man who stops asking for credit stops buying stock, and a man who stops buying stock loses his pitch, and a lost pitch on a bridge in Purewater does not come back in a generation. It wasn't twenty-six shillings. It was a hole in the bottom of the boat, and everybody was bailing and nobody had looked down.

It took her half a page. She used a fresh leaf because the sums wanted room.

Somewhere up the bridge a gull got into a basket and there was shouting and laughing and somebody threw a boot.

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Crowbill kept a counting room over a Chandler's on the Lullwater and he was in it with the shutters open, and he read the page standing up, all the way to the bottom, and said nothing at all while he read it and nothing at all for a while afterwards.

That silence was the single most nerve-racking thing that had ever happened to Kag, and she had once been hit in the head with a grappling hook.

"Twenty-six," he said.

"Off one bridge. This week."

"It's not skimming."

"No."

"Say it, then. Out loud, in this room, so I've heard you say it."

And here is the thing about being asked: she had been rehearsing this on the ferry and she had a whole speech, four sentences of careful

hedging with an exit built into every one of them, and when the moment came she threw all of it in the canal.

"They're not short because they're keeping it," Kag said. "They're short because there's four hundred armed men in this city helping themselves off the trestles, and there isn't one single person in that entire household you can present a bill to, and every trader on that bridge has worked that out for themselves and not one of them has said it out loud. They're not being robbed. They're being *asked*. And asked by men with swords is the same as robbed except you can't even have the grievance."

Crowbill turned the page over and looked at the back of it, which was blank, and turned it again.

"Nine weeks," he said, "and not one bill."

"Not one."

"Who else have you told?"

"You."

He put the page down on the ledge by the shutter and set a stone on it out of an old habit from when the wind came up off the Mouth, and then he looked at her for a moment in a way that nobody had ever looked at her, which was thoughtfully.

"Cost it by the day," he said. "The whole city, not your bridges. By Friday."

"You've got two men who do that."

"I've got two men who *count*. That is not the same thing and you have known it wasn't since you were about fifteen, and it is why I am asking you and not them."

She went down the stairs with her ears hot.

"Kag." He didn't come to the door. "Don't do anything about it."

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She did something about it at four in the afternoon, and in her defence she had genuinely not planned to.

There were four of them at the Fishmarket end in di Teufel green, young, bored, and standing in a line across the width of the bridge in that way soldiers stand when they have not worked out that a bridge is a road. One of them had a sack. The sack was going in, and the fish was going in the sack, and Mother Kessel, who bought that fish at three in the morning off a boat that wanted cash and had four children and a husband with one lung, was saying absolutely nothing.

That was the part. Forty people on that bridge and the only sound in the world was the sack.

It is never wise to be the only one talking.

“That’s stealing,” Kag said.

The one with the sack looked up. “*What?*”

“What you’re doing. There’s a word for it and the word’s stealing. You take a thing, you don’t pay, you leave no chit, and there’s nobody in your whole outfit a woman can bill. That’s not requisition. Requisition has paper.”

“Get out of the road.”

“She buys that at three in the morning with cash she hasn’t got,” Kag said, and she was aware, distantly, of the entire bridge having stopped, and of her own voice being extremely loud and extremely calm, “and you’ll eat it tonight and never think of it again, and honestly, fine, that’s soldiering, that’s what soldiers are. But don’t stand there and call it something else. You’re thieves. Say thieves.”

Nobody moved.

The young one with the sack went red from the collar up and started to say something, and the oldest of the four — a career man, thirty-five, tired — put a hand flat on his chest without looking at him.

“Move along, then,” the oldest one said, and there was something in it that was almost gratitude.

Kag moved along. She went up the south steps without hurrying and without looking back, and behind her the bridge stayed silent for four whole seconds.

Then forty people started talking at once, and somebody laughed, and the laugh went up the bridge and off it and into the lanes like a fire in a rope yard.

By dusk it was on the Lullwater. By the next morning she had been eight feet tall and there had been six of them and she had thrown one in the canal.

She hadn't thrown anybody in the canal. She had, however, been asked a question and answered it, and the answer had been repeated by four hundred people before breakfast, and that had never once happened to her in thirty years.

She should probably have felt worse about that than she did.

CHAPTER 2 — WHO MENDED HER



PELL WAS ELEVEN YEARS OLD AND HE HAD WORKED OUT, at about the age of six, in the way that children of the quays work things out — silently, completely, and without ever telling an adult they have done it — that the only protection available to a person like him was being useful. Not being liked. Not being pitied, which got you a heel of bread on a Tuesday and nothing on a Wednesday. *Useful*. Useful was a thing you could be on purpose, every day, and the terrible beauty of it was that it worked, it had never once failed him, and he had therefore never had to find out what he was without it.

So when Kag sent for him at half seven in the morning he ran the whole way, and arrived with his shirt off one shoulder, and stood in front of her breathing like a dog.

“You want me to find out who cut her,” Pell said.

“No.”

He waited. He was very good at waiting. It was one of his things.

“Everybody on this water is asking who cut her,” Kag said. She was sitting on the ice-house step with a bowl on her knee and she had the look she got when she was doing sums, which Pell privately thought made her look like she was in pain. “Forty people asking the same question, and by dinner they’ll all have been told the same three lies. I don’t want it.”

“What, then?”

“Go to the Pearl. In at the tradesmen’s door at Constantine’s, and ask the cook, and if the cook won’t have you, ask whoever’s at the wash. And what you ask them is this.” She put the bowl down. “Who *mended* her.”

Pell looked at her.

“Say it back.”

“Who mended her.”

“Not who cut her.”

“Who mended her.”

“That’s the whole of it. Don’t ask them anything else. Don’t tell them who sent you unless they ask twice — and if they ask twice, tell them, because it’s a house, and houses find out.”

“Why that one?” He was already moving his weight to the balls of his feet.

“Because a girl opened up like that bleeds out before dawn,” Kag said, “and it is eight in the morning and she is alive. Which means somebody in that house did a thing in the dark that a surgeon could not do. And whoever that is, is the only person in Purewater who was in the room.”

Pell was off the step.

“Eat something first.”

He came back for the bowl and took it with him, which he would remember for a long time, because nobody else in his life had ever made him take the food.

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The Pearl at eight in the morning smelled of cold lamp oil and last night, and he went in past two of Marisette’s men on the step who looked straight through him, because men on a step always did, and that was his entire profession.

The cook was a Lullwater woman called Bett with forearms like a bargee and she was crying into a pan of onions and pretending it was the onions.

“Who mended her,” Pell said.

And Bett stopped, and put the knife down, and looked at him properly, which never happened, and said: “That’s a better question than the Watch asked.”

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He had it inside the hour, and he had it whole, because once Bett started she didn’t stop and because a kitchen is where a house actually keeps its information.

An elf-girl had come in off the Anminster road on Monday with an old woman, the pair of them looking for work for Tourney week, and Constantine had put the old one on the front door and the elf on the water-stair. The old one was called Magda and was about sixty and had a face like a gatepost. The elf was called Gardwen and she had come down out of the deep woods somewhere and she had a *wolf*, an actual wolf, that lay across the second-floor landing and did not let anybody past it, and Constantine had let the wolf stay, which told you everything about how that week was going.

And when the screaming started the elf had gone up.

“She was in there an hour with her hands on her,” Bett said. “And the girl stopped dying. That’s all I can tell you and it’s all I’m going to say about it, and if you want more you can ask the elf, except she hasn’t come out of that room in two days, not to eat, not for anything.”

“Did the old woman see him?”

“The old woman was on the front door the whole night.” Bett went back to the onions. “He went out of a first-floor window rather than come past her, and that is the most sense that little bastard showed all night.”

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Pell ran it back across two ferries and told it to Kag on the ice-house step, and Kag wrote it in the book — *Gardwen — elf — wolf — was in the room* — and then did a thing she had never done in the fourteen months he had been running for her.

She read it back to him and asked if he'd got it right.

"That's what she said."

"Word for word?"

"Word for word."

"Then you've done a thing this morning that four hundred people couldn't," Kag said, still looking at the page. "They all went and asked who did it. You're the only one in this city who went and asked who saved her."

A beat.

"I'd have thought of it eventually," Pell said, which was a lie, and they both knew it, and Kag let him have it.

He did not go home that night and he did not eat again until nine, because he spent the whole of the afternoon on the Pearl quay on his own initiative, sitting on a bollard opposite the green shutters, watching.

And at one o'clock a girl came out with a basket of linen, and went down the water-stair, and came back up without it, and sat down on the step where she could see the front door. She was about thirteen. She was an elf, and thin as a rope, and barefoot on cold stone.

She didn't read. She didn't eat. She didn't speak to the men on the step.

She just watched the door, for twenty minutes, then for an hour, then for as long as Pell stayed, which was until the lamps went on.

He didn't know her name yet. He'd learn it inside two days and it would turn out to be Ila, and long afterwards, when he was a grown man with a boat of his own and a very great deal of money and three

children who thought he was boring, he would still not be able to explain why that afternoon was the one he remembered.

She was waiting for somebody to come and ask her something.

Nobody did.

CHAPTER 3 — TWENTY-FIVE TENTS



KAG WENT EAST UNDER A WATER BUTT, on her side, in the dark, with her knees up and her cheek on her own forearm, for two hours, because there is no other way to look at the Vantt estate and because everybody in Purewater had spent nine weeks repeating a number that not one single person had ever counted.

Four hundred men. That was the number. It had come down the Anminster road with the column and it had been in every mouth in the city ever since, and the extraordinary thing — the thing that had kept her awake on Tuesday night with the book open on her chest — was that it *couldn't* be checked. There are no roads in Purewater. The land stops dead at Caravan Square and everything past it goes on the water, and the Vantt estate was eleven miles east on dry ground where nobody from the city went and nobody from out there came in except in twos and threes to be unpleasant on a bridge.

So four hundred was not a fact. Four hundred was a rumour with armour on.

Sim's barge ran produce east three mornings a week and had done since before Kag was born, and the butt was empty and on its side in the bow with sacking over it, and it had a gap at the bung end you could get an eye to. She got in at four. Sim put the sacking over and poled off and never once said anything about the weight, which is the whole of what you want in a man.

She watched a strip of sky go past for two hours, and when the sky went from one grey to another grey she knew they were out of the city.

“Coming up on it,” Sim said, to nobody, the way a man talks to a boat.

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Through a bunghole you get about two feet of the world, and the barge went past the landing at a walking pace, and the whole of it took a little over four minutes.

She counted tents. There were twenty-five. She counted them twice and got twenty-five both times and then the angle shut and there was nothing more to see.

Eleven of them had no smoke.

Now. It was a cold morning. Every chimney on the Shoals was going and every brazier in the Lullwater was lit, and Kag had spent her whole life on water in October and knew exactly what men do on a cold morning, which is burn something. Eleven tents on a frozen meadow with nothing coming off them at all is not eleven tents of hardy lads. It is eleven tents with nobody in them.

Forty-one horses in the lines, and she wasn't sure of forty-one, so she wrote forty and a question mark, which was the single most honest thing in the book.

Two wagons, one with a wheel off, and the grass had come up around the axle.

She lay there with her cheek on her arm and did the sum while a man twelve feet away complained about bread.

Fourteen tents live. Eight to a tent is generous for a tent. Ten is a lie. Call it a hundred and twelve and call it a hundred and forty if you're being kind to them, and forty-one horses is a horse for every third man, which is not cavalry, that's a company with some riders in it and a farrier who's bored out of his skull.

Not four hundred.

Nothing like four hundred. Not a third of it. The entire occupation of Purewater — the thing that had shut the gate tolls, emptied the bridges, put four hundred armed men in the mouths of forty thousand people and taken sixty feet of best line off a rope-seller with no chit — was twenty-five tents, eleven of them cold, and a story.

And she was the only person alive who knew it.

That is a peculiar feeling to have while lying in a barrel.

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The two soldiers came down to the landing while the sacks were going off, and they were talking about bread, and Kag lay six feet from them with her eye at a hole and listened to the softest joint in the whole business come apart in front of her.

“He says Thursday.”

“He said Thursday *last* Thursday.”

“Then it’s Thursday, isn’t it.”

“There’s no flour out here and there’s flour eleven mile that way and not one bugger will sell it to us.”

“They’ll sell it to you.”

“They will *not*.” A boot went into the turf. “I stood in the Fishmarket an hour on Monday with money in my hand like a prick.”

They went off up the path. Somebody was hammering at the far end and stopped and started again.

That, thought Kag, with the absolute clarity that comes to a person at six in the morning in a barrel, *is a man who came down a road into a city that doesn’t have any, and now cannot feed himself without hiring us to do it.*

Outsiders can’t handle a boat. Everybody in Purewater knew it and nobody ever said it, because saying it was like announcing that water was wet. Every child on those canals could pole before they could

read. And the corollary — the thing that had been sitting in plain sight for nine weeks with a bow on it — was that Baron Hanzo di Teufel could not move a sack of flour across his own occupied city without paying a local to do it for him.

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She found out on the way back what he did about that, and it stopped being funny.

Sim brought the barge in at the Guild landing at ten and there were three watermen on the stones not working, which on a Thursday morning meant something had happened.

“Four o’clock,” one of them said. “Off this landing. Tam and the Mendick boy.”

“Took where?”

“*Took*. Two of them come down and said there was a fare, and they got in, and they’ve not come back, and Tam’s wife has been stood on this landing since six.”

“Whose boat?”

“Theirs. The green.”

Kag came out from under the sacking and stood up in the bow and none of the three looked surprised to see a half-orc unfold herself out of a water butt, because it had been that kind of morning.

“What time, exactly?”

“Four.”

“How do you know it was four?”

“Because the ice run goes out over the bar at four every morning of the year and Tam waved at it.”

She wrote it down. *Tam. Mendick boy. Guild landing. Four. Green boat. Waved at the ice.*

An hour before that, a man had come up this water soaked to the neck and poled east past the whiting boats in the dark, and one of

the whiting men had told his wife, and his wife had told the market, and by the time it reached Kag it had become a ghost, because that is what this city does with anything it doesn't understand by nine in the morning.

She sat on the gunwale and looked at the empty place on the landing where the green boat should have been, and she thought about a man's wife standing on wet stone since six with nothing to do with her hands.

Twenty-five tents was a thing to sell.

Two boatmen was a thing to answer for.

And Kag, who had been told very clearly by her own boss not to do anything about any of it, got up off the gunwale and went to find out what the Mother of Pearl knew.

CHAPTER 4 — THE MOTHER OF PEARL



MARISSETTE HAD GOVERNED ELEVEN HOUSES FOR TWENTY-TWO YEARS on nothing whatsoever except the settled expectation, held by everybody including her rivals, that she would still be there afterwards — and she knew precisely how thin that was, which was the difference between her and every proprietor who had ever tried to take the island off her. Authority, in her considered professional opinion, was a rumour you maintained. You maintained it by sitting when other people stood, by never once being seen to hurry, and by making sure that on the two or three occasions in a decade when somebody genuinely needed to find out what you were, you were worse than they had imagined.

She had a girl in a room four doors away with a wound running from her collarbone to her hip.

So the rumour was, at present, costing her a great deal to maintain.

The half-orc arrived at dusk and was shown up, and Marisette stayed sitting, as she did with everybody, and watched her fill the doorway and then decline to fill the room, which was interesting.

She talked for four minutes without being interrupted. Twenty-five tents. Eleven of them cold on a freezing morning. Forty-one horses and a wagon with grass grown up round the axle. No quartermaster. Nine weeks in this city and not one bill presented to anybody, anywhere, for anything.

Marisette let all of it come out and wrote none of it down.

“And what do you want?”

“Nothing.”

“Everybody wants something.”

“I’ve been asked for a number,” the half-orc said, “and I came back with a better one than I was asked for. You’ll hear it inside a week off somebody who’ll charge you for it. You can have it now, off me, for nothing.”

“On whose instruction?”

“Crowbill’s.”

The lamp was on the low table between them. Marisette moved it perhaps an inch, which put the light on both their faces instead of only one, and she did that out of pure habit and in no expectation of learning anything.

“No it isn’t,” she said.

And she watched the whole thing happen across that enormous grey face — the beat where a lie is abandoned, which most people cover and this woman simply did not — and Marisette, who had been lied to professionally by experts on four continents, thought: *oh, you poor creature, you are not built for this at all.*

“Sit down,” she said.

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She poured two glasses and pushed neither of them anywhere.

“He did not tell you to bring me that. He told you to cost the city and he told you not to do anything about it, and you have been doing something about it since Tuesday morning.” She drank. “I have run this island for twenty-two years on knowing which of my girls is lying to me and exactly why. You are very bad at it, and the reason you are very bad at it is that you almost never do it.”

“No.”

“No.” A beat. “So why bring it to me?”

“Because eleven houses shut is the largest thing that is going to happen in this city this week and it hasn’t happened yet.”

Marisette put the glass down.

She had told nobody. She had decided it at three that afternoon, alone, in this room, with the ledgers open and a headache coming on, and she had told not one living soul — not Constantine, not her own girls, not the man who did her accounts.

“Go on,” she said.

“When it happens, everybody is going to tell you he’s got four hundred men,” Kag said. “They’ll tell you it because they’ve heard it, and you’ll make your arrangements around it, and your arrangements will be wrong. He’s got a hundred and forty and he can’t get bread out to them. That’s the whole of what I came to say and I’d like it to reach you before the rest of it does.”

And this, Marisette reflected later, was the moment the evening turned, and it turned on something so unfashionable she could hardly bring herself to name it, which was that the woman had walked across a city in the dark to give her a thing she could have sold.

“There is a man in a cellar under this building,” Marisette said.

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His name was Sten and he was a Sword of the Lake and he had been down there since Tuesday afternoon, and the reason he was down there was that he had a beard and a dark coat and had been standing on Pearl Quay on the wrong night among two hundred other people who also had beards.

Hesper had taken him off the street without a sound and without a mark on him. Hesper did most things that way.

“He’s not your man,” Kag said.

“You have not seen him.”

"I don't need to see him. Whoever went out that window was a *client*." The half-orc counted it off on the table without touching anything, and her hands were the size of dinner plates and they were extremely precise. "In the house. Paid for the evening. Took a room upstairs and there'll be a name in your book for that room and it won't be the one he was born with. He was never on the quay. Your man in the cellar came to the quay after the screaming started, and so did four hundred other people, because that is what a quay is *for*."

Marisette looked at the table for slightly longer than she would have liked.

Twenty-two years, and it had taken a debt collector eleven seconds.

"Bring him up," she said to the girl on the stairs.

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They gave Sten his falchion back at the water door and he stood there a while because his legs weren't right, and he thanked Kag, which she plainly had not expected and which she handled about as gracefully as a dropped crate.

Marisette watched the pair of them from the window and worked out what she was going to do about it.

She had, at that point, a fairly complete inventory of the woman: employed muscle, Crowbill's, thirties, no house, no family anybody knew of, feared on eight bridges, and — this was the operative fact — invisible. Not physically. Seven feet of half-orc is not invisible. *Socially*. Nobody in this city had ever addressed a question to her that wasn't an instruction, and the woman had gone on being extremely good at something nobody had ever asked her to do, for years, on her own, out of some private and entirely unrewarded sense of professional pride.

Marisette knew exactly what that was like. She had done twelve years of it herself in rooms she did not discuss.

"Send her up to Constantine's," she told the girl. "Tell Constantine she's to have the room, and the lamp, and anything in it she wants."

"The room, madame?"

“The room.”

She did not go up herself. She had not been able to go into that room since Tuesday and she was not going to start being honest about why at this hour of the evening.

But she stood at the window a good while after the boat had gone, with the glass in her hand, doing sums of her own — eleven houses, four hundred and eleven people, the Governor, the Baron, a man with a face everybody in the city had now heard about, and a girl upstairs who had cut off all her hair with a kitchen knife on Tuesday and had not spoken since.

And somewhere underneath all of that, filed where she filed everything she intended to use later:

The big one thinks. Nobody has noticed. Do not be the third person in this city to make that mistake.

CHAPTER 5 — THE FOURTH OF JUNE



KAG WENT UP TO THE THIRD FLOOR AT CONSTANTINE'S EXPECTING HORROR and found instead the specific, domestic, unbearable thing that always turns out to be worse: a room nobody had cleaned, because nobody cleans a room while a girl is dying in the one next door.

A basin with the water still in it. A shift over the back of a chair. Somebody's slippers under the bed, side by side, the way you leave them when you expect to want them again.

She didn't touch anything for ten minutes. She got down on the boards with the lamp on the floor and looked along them at eye height, which is a trick she had off a man who salvaged, and then she put her shoulder behind the armoire and walked it out from the wall and put it back.

It was lying against the skirting where it had gone.

Eleven inches, and it was not a weapon. The back edge was barbed the whole length of it — not serrated, *barbed*, small swept-back hooks like fish-hooks — and those are for opening a thing slowly and holding it open while you work, and the moment Kag understood what she was looking at she had to put her hand flat on the boards for a second.

There was a groove down the flat. The grip was wound with something dark that was not leather and she elected, as a matter of policy, not to think about that today.

And set into the pommel, small, and beautifully done by somebody who had been paid properly for it: a ring with a line through it and three strokes off the line.

She did not pick it up.

This was the single best decision she made all week and she made it for entirely unglamorous reasons — she was a debt collector, and a debt collector knows that the moment a thing is in your hand it is *yours*, and that a knife on a floor in a house with a witness in the doorway is worth ten of the same knife in a thief's pocket four days later. So she got down with her cheek nearly on the boards and turned it a quarter-turn with the back of her own knife, so the pommel came up into the lamplight, and she tore a leaf off the back of Constantine's ledger and took a stub of charcoal out of her coat and took a rubbing.

Four goes, because the boards weren't flat. The fourth came out clean.

"You'll want the grate," Constantine said from the door.

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There were three pieces in the grate and they came up in three pieces and a great deal of black that went to nothing between her fingers.

What survived was the middle. Two palm-sized pieces of heavy paper, scorched brown at the margins and still cream in the centre, and a third the size of a playing card, and there was writing on them. Not printing — a dense sloping hand in brown ink with the letters run together, and in among the lines, drawn small and exact, figures. One of them was a ring with a line through it and three strokes off the line, twice over, and the rest of them Kag had never seen and did not like.

The paper was warm.

There was no fire in that grate and had not been for two days.

"Whose hand?" said Constantine.

"Not his."

"Not whose?"

“Not a nineteen-year-old’s.” Kag turned the biggest piece to the lamp. “That’s a man who’s written this sort of thing a hundred times and doesn’t have to think about the shape of his letters. That’s fifty years of holding a pen.”

And Constantine — forty-six, forearms out, proprietor of a house of other people’s daughters for twenty years — went to the washstand and came back with a pen and an ink bottle and the house ledger, the actual one, the one she did standing up, and opened it on the bed and began to write, fast, in a clear round hand.

“Half three or thereabouts. The twenty-first.” The nib scratched. “The knife where it lies, behind the armoire, against the skirting, not moved. Three pieces of burnt paper out of the grate, taken by—”

She stopped.

“Kag.”

“Kag what?”

“Kag of no house,” Kag said. “It’s the only one I’ve got.”

Constantine wrote it and dated it and blotted it with the heel of her hand, and it was, although neither of them knew it that night, the most dangerous object anybody in Purewater would produce that week.

“Come back in daylight and I’ll countersign the paper.”

*
**

The Forge Quarter starts before the sun does.

It is High Isle’s eastern point and it is hammers, a dozen of them going at different speeds out of different sheds, and under that the bellows-roar and the shriek of something being drawn. Coal smoke, hot iron, quench-water, and from the tanneries at the north end a thing that gets into the back of your throat and lives there. Grit on everything. It is the only quarter in Purewater where the water runs black, and the dwarves who run half of it have been complaining about that for two hundred years and about six other things for considerably longer.

Kag took a cookshop bench at six with a bowl and a view of three sheds and sent Pell in with the rubbing.

He was *good* at it. Hands empty, same words every time — *Kag'd like to know who cut this, please* — and he never touched anything. Three men sent him off. The fourth didn't.

The fourth was Orsk & Daughter, cutters and engravers, four generations on the water at the end of the founders' lane. Old Orsk was seventy and didn't come out from the back any more. It was the daughter who came to the door with the rubbing held up close to her eyes, fifty-odd, arms like a cooper's, and she was not pleased.

Her name was Hild.

"Where's the knife?"

"On a floor."

"Whose floor?"

"A girl's, at the Sylph's Embrace. He opened her from the collar-bone to the hip with it and went out of a window."

Hild stood in her own doorway with the slip in her fingers for a long moment.

"Girl live?"

"She lived."

"Right." Hild turned the slip over. "Then you can have it."

*
**

She went to the ledger first, because dwarves go to the ledger first. It was chained to the bench and it had four generations in it and she ran a blunt finger down a column and her whole face changed.

"I said nine weeks. That's wrong, I was going off the job and not off the book."

She turned it round and tapped the line.

4 June. Mark cut to drawing, pommel, fine. 2s 6d. Paid whole.

Four months.

Kag looked at that date for a long time, and the bellows went next door, and the whole shed breathed in.

The column had come down the Anminster road nine weeks ago with four hundred men that weren't four hundred men and every bell in three villages going. That mark had been cut in this shed *four months before that*. Before the Baron was a rumour. Before anybody in Purewater had heard the name di Teufel said in anger.

Which meant it had not come into the city. It had been waiting here.

"Tell me about him."

"Purewater man. Fifty-five or so. Ink on the middle finger and not the first, which is a man who's held a pen fifty years." Hild shut the book. "Paid cash. In forty years I've had perhaps three men pay cash for engraving."

"What did he look like?"

"He'd cut the buttons off his coat."

"He'd *what*?"

"Cut them off. Both rows. There was thread where they'd been and he'd not tidied it." Hild put both hands flat on the bench. "I thought he'd come down in the world and was ashamed of it, and I was sorry for him, and I did him a lovely job for two and six."

She looked up.

"He was frightened the entire time he was in this shed."

*

**

The Pearl went dark at ten that morning and it took Marisette one hour.

By noon it was the only subject in the city, and the Fishmarket bridge was carrying ten times its usual traffic because half of an island had nowhere to be, and Kag costed it on the ice-house step before the bells had finished.

Eleven houses. Four hundred and eleven people on that island who lived off them — the girls, the cooks, the linen women, the boatmen who did nothing all year but the Pearl run, the boy who did the lamps, the four fiddlers, the woman who sold hot pastries on the quay at two in the morning to people coming out warm and generous. Four hundred and eleven, and she had the number because she had five years of that island's traffic in the back of her book and had never once had a reason to add it up.

A hundred and thirty pounds a day off the island. A week of it cost more than the entire occupation had cost the Shoals since the column came down the road.

She brought it to Crowbill, and he read it standing up, and then he sat down, which he never did.

"That's more in one night than they've cost me all week."

"Yes."

"So what's the answer?"

"You know the answer."

"Say it anyway."

"The answer is you go to the Baron with a purse and you settle." Kag kept her eyes on the page. "You pay him to keep his boys off the stalls and you cover Marisette's losses for a fortnight out of the same purse, and the island opens tomorrow and everything in my book comes right inside a month. That's the arithmetic and I did it twice and it's not close."

Crowbill waited. He was exceptionally good at waiting.

"And I'll not do it," Kag said.

"No?"

"He hasn't got four hundred men. He's got twenty-five tents and eleven of them are cold and he cannot move a sack of flour across this city without hiring one of us to carry it." She closed the book. "He is not an army sitting on us. He's a *bluff*. And the price of a bluff goes

up every single time somebody pays it. You settle this one and you'll be paying the next at Michaelmas and a bigger one at Candlemas, and by the spring this is not your city, it's his, and you'll have bought that yourself with your own money."

And then, because she had come this far and there was no sense stopping:

"You asked me for a number. That's the number, and the number says settle, and I'm telling you the number's wrong and I'm telling you why. That is the whole of what I'm actually for, and in nine years you have never once let me do it."

Crowbill sat there a long while.

Then he got up and opened a drawer that Kag had never seen open in her life, and took out a slate with names on it, and turned it round.

There was one price, and he set it at the end.

"The twenty-five stays in this yard. Not on a bridge, not to Marisette, not to some Sword of the Lake with a nice face and a sad story. The day that gets out is the day they find out we've counted them — and then they have to either leave or make it true, and I don't want either of those happening on a Thursday."

*
**

The presentation of the entrants was that afternoon and half the city half-watched it, because by long form every competitor goes bare-headed in front of the Crown's representative for the space of a bow, and it is ceremony, and it is boring, and the Baron could not skip it without forfeiting his entry.

So they walked the champion out in harness with the rest of them, and the helm came off for about four seconds.

He was seventeen. He was far too thin for the armour he was in and he had the white skin of something kept a long time without light, and he stood in the sun in front of several hundred people and did not blink, and Kag — who was there for entirely mercenary reasons,

counting colours and working out which houses had money — felt the back of her neck go cold for no reason she could have named.

Thirty yards away on the competitors' ground, an elf with a wolf at her heel made a noise that Kag heard over four hundred other people.

She got there before the old woman did.

"That's my brother," Gardwen said. She had both hands on the rail. She wasn't crying. "Ten years. They took him at seven. He's been thirty yards from me since Monday."

"What do you want?"

And Gardwen told her, fast, all of it in one breath: the Baron's son, taken, held, and traded, tonight, and she would do it herself if nobody would help her.

"No," Kag said.

"Then—"

"No, and I'll tell you why, and then I'll tell you what I'll do instead." Kag put her back against the rail so she was facing the crowd, because that is how you have a conversation on a ground with four hundred people on it. "You take a lordling hostage and you've started a war, and the war doesn't happen to you. It happens on the Shoals and the Lullwater and in the low canals where four thousand people live on planks, and not one of them has ever heard your brother's name."

"That's your answer."

"That's the *cost*. You asked me the wrong question." Kag looked out at the ground. "Here's mine. I'll bring your brother to Crowbill. Not the lordling — him. And Crowbill can hide a thing in this city that a Baron couldn't find with four hundred men, which as it happens he hasn't got, and he's been doing it since before either of us was born."

Gardwen looked at her for a long moment, and something in her face came apart and was put back differently.

"Nobody in this city has offered me anything," she said.

“Nobody in this city has asked you a question either.” Kag shrugged. “I’m asking. What does he answer to?”

And the woman from the woods told her his name, and it was Cailan, and it was the first time anybody in Purewater had said it out loud in ten years.

CHAPTER 6 — A LETTER IN HER OWN HAND



EMMERALDA HAD BEEN WANTED BY EVERYBODY FOR FIFTEEN YEARS and asked what she wanted by almost nobody, and the great private joke of her life — the one she had never told a soul, not the girls, not Constantine, certainly not any of the men who wrote her poetry — was that she had been counting. Not money. Years. She had decided at twenty-two that she would give it until she was thirty-eight and then she would stop, and go somewhere with water and no lamps, and feed cats, and never again be the most interesting thing in a room.

She had two years left on that count when a nineteen-year-old opened her from the collarbone to the hip with a barbed knife because she had laughed at him.

On the Thursday morning she had been awake since six, and she had spoiled ten sheets of paper.

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The trouble was not the words. The trouble was that every version she wrote was a version of herself, and she had been performing versions of herself for fifteen years, and she could do the frightened one and the yearning one and the sly one in her sleep — and every single one of them read, when she looked at it in the grey light with her ruined hair hanging in her eyes, like a woman writing a love letter to the man who had cut her.

Which it was. That was the point. That was precisely and exactly the point, and knowing it did not help at all.

Sheet six had got as far as *my dear*.

Sheet nine had two words on it.

Gardwen sat on the boards beside the chair with her knees up and did not say anything for hours at a time, and the wolf lay across the landing, and the grey cat that had followed her home in the spring sat on the sill with its feet folded under it as though nothing whatsoever had happened, which was, if she was honest, the only company she could stand.

Then the door went, and the half-orc came in.

*
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She was enormous and she stood too far inside the room the way big people do when they are trying not to loom and are therefore looming in a new place, and she put a silver hair-comb down on the table beside the inkwell.

His comb. Dusty in the teeth from wherever Marisette had been keeping it.

Emmeralda stopped writing and looked at it.

There was nothing on her head any more to put it in. She had done that herself on Tuesday with a kitchen knife, sitting on this floor, and she had no memory at all of deciding to.

She looked at the comb anyway, for considerably longer than it took.

Then she pulled the coat closed at her throat with one hand and went back to the page, because if she looked at it one second more she was going to do something with it that she would have to explain.

“He’ll want to know I kept it hidden from Constantine,” she said. “That’s the part he’ll like.”

And then, because she had nothing left and this woman had at least brought the thing instead of sending it:

“Tell me something I can write that only he knows.”

*
**

“I can’t help you there,” the half-orc said.

Emmeralda waited, because waiting was a professional skill and she had eighteen years of it.

“If you want something off me it’ll be numbers of people crossing bridges,” Kag said, “or what a house takes in a night off one room, or what a boat of Anminster wool is worth at the Guild landing on a Tuesday against a Friday. That’s what I’ve got.” A shrug of enormous shoulders. “You’re the only person alive who knows the man. I do need the letter soon, mind. There’s the whole of it to set up.”

And Emmeralda laughed.

It came out of her before she could stop it and it was a horrible, cracked, unused sound, and it was the first laugh in that room in four days, and Gardwen’s head came up off her knees at the sound of it.

Bridges.

Of course. Of *course*. She had been sitting here since six o’clock trying to write herself, and what was actually wanted was a piece of work — a thing with a job to do, costed, delivered, the way you would order rope.

“Bridges,” she said. “All right, then.”

After that she wrote fast and did not stop, and the paper kept trying to lift off the table in the draught until Gardwen got up without a word and pulled the far window down to a hand’s width and sat back down again.

Four lines. Six. She turned it over and did three more on the back.

What she put in it was this, and she gave it to the half-orc plainly, because there was no version of saying it that improved with softening:

“He told me I’d be out of this house inside a year, and I laughed at him.” She blotted it with the heel of her hand rather than wait for sand, because she was not going to sit in front of these two waiting for sand. “I’ve put that he was right. That I shouldn’t have laughed. That I can get out for an hour after the bell tonight and that I’m frightened of Constantine.”

A beat.

“Every word of that is true except the last one, and he’ll believe the last one hardest, because it’s the one that makes him the rescue.”

She folded it twice and pressed the crease flat with her thumbnail and held it out, and the coat fell open at the throat and she did not bother with it that time.

“Who’s carrying it?”

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The half-orc asked who had carried the others, and Emmeralda answered before she had finished hearing the question, which is how she knew she had been dreading it since dawn.

“Ila. Both times.” The pen went down flat on the table. “And you’re not having her.”

The window Gardwen had left at a hand’s width whistled a little.

Gardwen was not looking at Emmeralda any more. Gardwen was looking at the door.

Ila was in it.

Thirteen years old, elven, thin as a rope, barefoot on cold boards with a jug of water somebody had sent her for, and she had plainly been standing on that landing with the wolf for some time.

“I took the first one in a basket of his own shirts, back to the barge landing,” Ila said, with no particular weight on any of it. “The second I gave to the boy in the green coat at the Fishmarket end, because he’d started coming that way.”

She looked at the folded paper in Kag’s hand.

“He never looked at me once.”

*
**

There was an argument after that and Emmeralda lost it, and she lost it because the child was right and because the half-orc did not once raise her voice and because Ila, who had no social reflexes at all and had never in her life softened anything for anybody, simply put her hand out and asked whether she was going.

Nobody had ever asked Ila for anything either. That was the whole trouble with this house. That was the whole trouble with the entire island, come to that, and Emmeralda had spent fifteen years not saying so.

She got up. It took her longer than it should have and she did it without holding on to anything, because she was not going to hold on to anything in front of a child.

And then she did the only thing left that was hers to do.

She crossed the room and took the comb out of the half-orc’s hand before it got to the girl, and wrapped it in one of the spoiled sheets, folding the ends over the way you wrap a fish, and put it into Ila’s palm with the letter on top of it, and closed the child’s fingers around both of them and held them shut.

“Don’t wait for him to read it.”

That was the whole of it. Eighteen years of being the finest performer on the Pearl and that was the only useful thing she had ever had to teach anybody.

She went back to her chair and sat down, and she did that carefully too.

Ila had already put the bundle inside her shift and was gone down the stairs with her bare feet not making any sound at all, past a wolf who lifted her head and put it down again.

Emmeralda picked up the pen, looked at the ten spoiled sheets, and began to tidy them into a stack, because her hands wanted something and there was nothing else on the table.

She was still doing it when the light changed.

CHAPTER 7 — THE LANDING



ILA HAD BEEN TOLD TO BE SOMEWHERE ELSE FOR FOUR DAYS, by adults who were managing their own grief so badly that they had entirely failed to notice she was managing hers alone, on a step, in the cold, where she could see the front door — and she had decided, at some point on the Wednesday, without telling anybody, that she was going to do something about it.

She was thirteen. She had lived at the Sylph's Embrace since she was nine. Emmeralda had taught her to read out of a book of shipping notices because it was the only book in the house that wasn't filthy, and had fed her every single night for four years without once making a performance of it, and had cried in front of her exactly twice, and had never, not once, told her to go and be somewhere else.

So on Thursday morning, when the enormous grey woman came up the stairs and the room went quiet in that particular way that means adults are about to arrange something without you, Ila stood in the doorway with a jug she hadn't been sent for and said the true thing, which was that he had never once looked at her.

Nobody argued with it, which surprised her.

She got her shoes.

*
**

The Long Butts had four thousand people on it by noon and every single one of them was complaining about the wind, which was coming off the open water across the range instead of along it and had been doing it since before light.

Ila went up the slope with a basket of somebody else's washing on her hip — three different houses' linen in one basket, which was the sort of detail that never mattered and this once did — and she went slowly, and she stopped twice, and she watched.

That was the whole of what Kag had told her. *Don't hurry, don't be clever, and look at the ground before you walk on it.*

The ground was this: a stone quay at the west end where the slope ran out, nine steps down to the water, a bollard line, and four thousand people who were all, in about two hours, going to want it at the same moment.

The household box was black with six chairs and five of them were full.

He was in the one on the right, forward in the seat with his elbows on the rail, watching the shooting like a boy at a fair, and he was nineteen years old and quite beautiful and he had opened Emmeralda up the length of her body with a barbed knife, and Ila looked at him for a long time from forty feet away in a crowd of four thousand and felt nothing whatsoever except a great and useful clarity.

The wide grey man stood on the stone below the box and read the crowd in slow sweeps, left to right, the way you read a page.

*

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The elf in plain harness won the archery, which Ila did not really watch, and afterwards there were ninety seconds in front of the Governor's box where four thousand people leaned forward and waited for something.

The elf took the wreath and said eleven words and walked off the grass.

The slope didn't know what to do with that and cheered anyway, and Ila thought, with the ruthlessness available only to the very young: *you had them and you didn't use it.*

Then the horn went for the close, and four thousand people stood up at once and started thinking about the water, and it happened exactly the way the half-orc had said it would at dawn.

They came off the slope. The landing took forty at a time. The boats were not ready and were never going to be ready, because Purewater boatmen have never in the history of that city been ready for anybody in a hurry. And the household came down onto the stone with everybody else and stood in it — the Baron with two knights at his shoulder, and the son three feet from a fishmonger's wife with a live crab in a bag.

Ila went in from the bollard side.

She came up on his blind side, which is the side away from the water, because a man on a quay watches the water. The bundle went from her hand to his without either of them looking down at it. He closed his fingers on it out of pure reflex, the way a man takes a note at a party.

She was four people away before he'd understood he was holding anything.

It was perfect. It was absolutely perfect, and she knew it was perfect, and she was eleven feet clear and already composing how she would tell Bett about it.

And then there was a hand around the top of her arm.

*
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He did not grab her. That was the thing she would think about afterwards, on and off, for years. He put his hand round her arm the way you take hold of a gate — no squeeze in it, no shake — and turned her to face him, and crouched slightly so that his eyes were level with hers, which no adult had done to her since she was seven.

Up close he was thin and white-skinned and red-eyed with old burn down one side of his face into the collar, and he smelled of nothing at all.

“What’s your name?”

And Ila, who had no social reflexes, who did not move aside for people, who did not soften things and had never learned to perform, heard herself say: “Ila.”

“Where are you taking that washing, Ila?”

“The Promise of Heaven.”

Which was a lie, and it was a good lie, and it came out of her flat and unblinking — and she watched him receive it, and file it, and not believe it, all without moving his face at all.

“That’s not true,” he said, without any unkindness whatsoever. “But I’m not going to do anything about it, because I have hold of a child in a crowd and that is not a thing I do.”

Eight seconds. That was the whole of it. Eight seconds and a name.

*
**

What saved her was the water, and the water was not an accident.

Somewhere behind her in the press the whole landing lurched — forty people going forward at once because a boat had finally come alongside — and a woman two along from the grey man lost the stone entirely and went in between the hull and the steps with a shriek and a great green gout of canal.

Three men grabbed. The grey man let go of Ila’s arm and took the woman’s wrist and hauled her out one-handed onto the stone like a man landing a net, and set her on her feet, and looked around.

Ila was already gone, over the Fishmarket bridge and home by the back of the ice-houses, running the way she had been taught by nobody at all.

She was sick twice on the way, behind the ice-houses, quietly, and then went in the water door and up the back stairs and sat down on the second-floor landing with her arms round the wolf, who put up with it.

*
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Out on the water, the household's boat pulled for High Isle. A nineteen-year-old sat in the stern with one hand flat inside his coat, looking at the wake and not at anybody, already composing the rest of his life.

And on the stones the wide grey man stood a while in the thinning crowd with his hat in his hands, turning over a name he had been given for nothing by a child who had lied to him about everything else.

He did not use it that day. He did not use it the next day either.

He was extremely good at his job, and the worst thing about him — the thing that made him worse than any of the men with swords — was that he never once had to hurry.

CHAPTER 8 — NINE STEPS



KAG HAD NEVER IN HER LIFE RUN ANYTHING, and standing at the top of the Lily Garden's back water-stair in the dark with a wet rope in her hand and six people's evenings arranged around a thing she had thought of on Tuesday, she discovered that the sensation was not power at all. It was closer to being very cold. Every part of it was somebody else's body. Tess on the fourth step in Emmeralda's grey. Hesper eight feet below in a boat with a rod propped up, pretending to fish, in a coat and a hat and a complete absence of anything describable. Deri and Fen on the stone at the top, forty feet apart, arguing quietly about a horse in the way of two married men who had been told to look bored and were overdoing it.

The whole plan was made of people, and people are not rope, and you cannot test them beforehand.

The stair itself was four feet of wet stone and nine steps down to a dead end, with a gate at the top you could lift off its pins with one hand, and there was no lamp past the gate, which was the entire reason it had been chosen.

And then it was the waiting, which is the part nobody puts in the stories.

The water slapped. Somebody two houses over was having precisely the same argument they had been having the night before. The wet line came up out of the dark from Hesper's hand to hers and

she could feel the boat breathe on it, once every few seconds, like something asleep.

Full dark, and she could see all of it, because she always could.

*
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Twenty minutes past the bell a skiff came up from the seaward end with no lamp on it, moving slow, three people in it.

Two of them were poling, one fore and one aft, standing up and easy with it — Purewater men, because nobody out of a country with roads stands up in a boat — and the third sat amidships with a cloak up over his head.

At twenty feet the cloak came off, because he could not help wanting to see the steps.

Nineteen. Dark hair. A plain brown thing over something that had cost a great deal more, and one hand flat inside the front of it.

And the man on the aft pole was Tam.

Tam. Off the Guild landing, four o'clock Thursday morning, not seen on this water since, with a wife who had stood on wet stone since six. Standing up in that boat poling the Baron's son to a dead-end stair and looking back over his shoulder the whole way up the canal like a man being marched.

There is a particular kind of anger that arrives without heat and simply rearranges what you are prepared to do.

Kag pulled the line.

*
**

It came tight, and somewhere below her in the dark Hesper said one word — not loudly, the way you say a name across a room — and Tess went over sideways on the fourth step with her cheek on the stone, out, breathing, exactly as advertised.

Santo di Teufel did not.

He stood there a second and a half looking at a girl who had just fallen asleep at his feet at the bottom of a dead-end stairwell, and then he ran, and he ran the *wrong way* — down, at the water, because the top of the steps had two men on it and because water had been the way out of everything his entire life.

Kag came down nine wet steps.

He got one foot onto the gunwale of Hesper's skiff and the skiff did what a skiff does under one foot, and then there was a forearm across his chest and that was the whole of it. Ten stone of nineteen-year-old in a very good coat. He kicked once and gave it up, and the letter came out of the front of his coat with the comb still folded in the spoiled page.

Hesper had already sat back down and picked up the rod.

Six feet away Tam stood in the other boat with the pole in his hands and his mouth open, and he had known Kag eleven years.

She winked at him over the top of the boy's head.

Tam shut his mouth, and after a moment jerked his chin about a quarter of an inch, and turned his face out to the canal like a man who has come out to look at the weather.

*
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They had a room ready off the landing at the Mother of Pearl with a stone floor and a drain in the middle of it, because it was where they washed the linen, and one chair carried in from somewhere else.

He went into it hard enough that it moved.

Marisette came in behind and did not hurry and sat down on a stool by the wall and arranged her skirts as though it were any other Thursday in any other room in her house. Fen put the lamp on the floor and the light went up the walls, which made it worse, and Kag noticed him do it and thought: *you have done this before*.

Emmeralda walked the four doors herself.

She came in the big coat with her hair off at the jaw, and asked to be let in, and Kag looked at her for a second and then opened the door, and that was a decision that Kag would turn over a great many times afterwards and never once regret.

He heard the door and looked up expecting the madame.

And his whole face changed — not fear, the other thing, the worse thing — and he came forward against the cord as far as it let him and made a sound through the gag that had a shape to it, and the shape was her name, and he did it three times.

He thought the letter had worked.

He thought she had come.

Emmeralda stood in the doorway and looked at him with the lamp on him, and then she said, quite evenly, “Take that out of his mouth.”

*
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They took it out and he worked his jaw twice and there was a red line across both cheeks.

“Em.” His voice had not finished breaking, which was the single most obscene thing in that room. “I got your letter.”

Then he waited. He genuinely *waited*, with his hands tied behind a chair on a wet stone floor, the way you wait for somebody to pass you the salt.

She crossed the stone and stopped a yard in front of him.

“It wasn’t meant to be like that,” he said, low and fast, as though the two of them were alone and everybody else were furniture he hadn’t got round to. “You know it wasn’t.”

She went on looking at him.

“I can still take you out of here. Tonight. I’ve got the boat.”

And Emmeralda unfastened the coat.

She did not do it quickly and she did not do it for effect. She opened it and held it open and stood there in a shift in a cold room, and the

line he had put down her went from her collarbone to her hip, closed now, and pink, and perfectly straight, and there was a very great deal of it.

He turned his head away.

She waited.

He turned his head away again, and she waited again, and the third time he looked, because there was nowhere in that room that was not her.

Then she closed the coat and held it shut at the throat with one hand, the way she had all day, and walked out past Kag and stopped in the doorway with her back to the room.

"He's about five foot nine," she said, and went up the stairs.

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Crowbill was in the back of an ice-house on the Shoals at two in the morning with a lamp and a blanket over his knees, because that is where Crowbill was at two in the morning, and he heard the whole of it and did not interrupt once.

Then he named his price, and it was not what she had been braced for.

"When Marisette has him in a chair, I want the asking. The Baron on a boat and gone inside the week, and not one word said out loud about anybody's face." A beat. "And you'll be the one who tells the two of them that. Not me."

So Kag went back and told them, whole, including the part that took everything away from them, and Marisette held her glass halfway up for about as long as it takes a cat to cross a room and then drank it.

"Eleven houses are going to ask me why we opened and nothing was said," she said. "And I shall have to let them think what they think."

Emmeralda did not come off the wall through any of it.

*
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And later, in the ice-house again, Kag gave him the other half, and this was the part where she stopped being a person who costs things and became something she did not have a word for.

“He’s not going to trade for that boy,” she said. “He’s got a champion and a city to take and one son he has never in nine weeks been seen to like, and if we hand the boy back the only thing we’ve bought is his attention. He won’t pay. He’ll remember. And then in about a month he’ll come and find every single person who touched it, starting with the ones who can’t afford a door.”

“Then what?”

“Then Marisette gets her answers out of him. And then he’s fish food. And the twelve of us go on knowing that he rode out of this city with a girl — which two bridges of people watched happen on Tuesday night, and every one of them believes it, because Randall wore the coat and Tess wore the grey and nobody had to be told to lie about anything.”

The ice ticked and settled somewhere behind him in the dark.

“Not the Lullwater,” Crowbill said at last. “The pots are off the Lost Isle and the men who lift them are mine and they don’t look in.”

He trimmed the lamp without looking at it.

“And you’ll do it yourself. Not Deri. Not Fen. Not some fellow I’d have to pay and then worry about for eleven years.” He was entirely pleasant about it, the way he had been all week. “Eleven people can carry a story about a boy who ran off with a girl. Twelve people cannot carry a murder. So it’s one pair of hands, and they’re yours.”

Kag said of course, and that she didn’t mind that at all, and gave him the best orc smile she had.

She had never killed anybody in her life.

CHAPTER 9 — THE ICE RUN



KAG HAD EXPECTED IT TO BE HARDER, and the thing she was not prepared for — the thing nobody warns you about, because the people who could warn you have all made a private arrangement not to discuss it — was how ordinary it was, and how completely the world declined to mark it.

He went down into the boat still in a girl's blue cloak with his feet bare, and he did not fight, because it had not yet occurred to him that there was anything to fight. He had been told nothing. He had spent four hours in a chair on a wet floor being asked questions by a mage in plain clothes who never once raised their voice, and he had answered all of them, at length, eagerly, the way a clever boy answers a tutor, because being asked about his father's work was the closest thing to affection anybody had offered him in a year.

Out past the last of the Pearl the light came up grey off the water. The Lost Isle was a low green nothing with a fringe of poles in the shallows where the pots were set. Nobody lives on it. The men who lift the pots come at nine.

He asked one question on the way over, about halfway.

"Is my father paying?"

She did not answer him, and after a while he stopped expecting one, and then he sat and watched the water go past exactly the way anybody does.

It was quick, and it was done from behind, and he did not see it coming.

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The rest of it was work, and it is a strange mercy of this world that work is always available to a person who needs the next ten minutes to have a shape.

There is a gutting board on the stilt-shed that the pot-men use, and a knife on a lanyard, and a bucket. The pots went down full and heavy on the far string where the water runs deep and cold. The blue cloak went down with a stone in it somewhere else entirely, because you never put two things in one place. The board got three buckets of seawater and a scrub with sand and another three buckets.

The tide turned while she was washing her arms.

And that was all. There was no thunder. No gull did anything significant. The sun came up over the Mouth the way it comes up over the Mouth about three hundred and sixty times a year, and somewhere eleven miles east a hundred and forty men were waking up in a cold field to find there was still no bread.

She sat on the stilt-shed steps for four minutes with her wet hands on her knees and let herself have those, and then she got in the boat.

Afterwards, when people asked her about that week — and eventually people did ask her, because that is what happens to you once a story gets loose — she would talk about the bridge, or the bill, or the pier, and she would be generous and funny about all of it.

She never once mentioned the Lost Isle.

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By the time she was back on the Shoals the city had stopped working, and it had stopped working *politely*, which was the part that made it beautiful.

There was a Dragon Knight on the Fishmarket steps trying to hire a boatman to take him to High Isle, and not one of the six men sitting

there was looking up. There was no ice. There was no bread off the Fishmarket. There was no boat at the Vanttt landing and no boy to run a message and no rope to be had when a man wanted rope, and everybody was very, very sorry about all of it.

Nobody was rude. That was the instruction and that was the genius of it. You cannot put a city to the sword for being apologetic.

Four Knights rowed themselves to High Isle that morning in a hired boat with nobody to hire, and went round and round in the Lullwater for twenty minutes while the fish market watched in reverent silence, and one of them lost his pole and had to be given it back by a nine-year-old.

Nobody laughed out loud.

The entire city laughed for the rest of the year.

*

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Temple Isle has no bridge to it, so half of Purewater was afloat by first light, gunwale to gunwale in a great slow ring off the steps with families standing up in the boats and children on shoulders and a man working the outside of the ring selling something hot out of a tub, which is the most Purewater fact available about any religious occasion.

The Sacred Confluence comes down off the temple in shallow terraces to a pool at the waterline and a broad stair of wet green stone, and by the Order's long form every combatant and the head of their house goes down to be blessed before the sand. Nerissa's novices worked the running order with white rods and not one atom of deference to anybody, which Kag enjoyed enormously.

The di Teufels were called near the end.

The Baron came down the green stone with his shirt off and there it was: a flat black chain, close to the throat, and something small on it under the hollow of his collarbone. Nine weeks in this city and nobody had ever seen him without it, and here he was in front of four thousand

people stripped to the waist on somebody else's ground, because the Lady's water does not care whose army you brought.

And behind him, bare-headed in daylight for the second time in his life, came a boy of seventeen who was too thin for the body he was in and who walked like somebody being walked.

The stair packed solid behind them with forty people trying to see.

A body-length off the Baron's left shoulder, going down the steps with his head turned the other way, was a nineteen-year-old thief called Nus who had the best hands on that water and had been circling Kag for two days looking for somebody to tell him he was the man for it.

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The priestess put the Baron under with a hand flat on the back of his neck and held him there a good deal longer than that man had been held anywhere in nine weeks, and Kag, sitting in a hired skiff twenty-five metres out, revised her opinion of the Order considerably upwards.

He came up streaming. Somebody put a cloth in his hands. The whole stair closed in behind to get the boy in next, and for about four seconds there was nothing on those steps but wet backs and elbows.

Nus went past him on the step above, close as a man passing in a corridor, and his hand went across the Baron's throat and off again, and he kept walking.

Nothing came away in his fist.

And nothing happened, either — the Baron did not turn round, because he had a cloth over his face and his son's killer was twenty-five metres away in a hired boat and a thief had just had his fingers on the thing at his throat, and he was drying his eyes.

Kag was the only person on that water who saw it, and she was the only person who saw *why*.

There was no clasp on it.

It was a closed ring, worn short and tight at the collarbone, and it had been on that man since before any of this started, and it did not lift and it did not come over a head. It came off with a cut, off the living man, or it did not come off at all.

Nus got to the top of the stair and turned and found her across the water, and stood there, waiting to be told.

And Kag shook her head. Once. That was the entire conversation.

Something went out of his shoulders, and he turned and went up between the temple wall and the crowd and did not look back.

*

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She would find out weeks later what that had cost — or rather what it had *not* cost, which is a harder thing to be told about and impossible to feel properly.

Below the Fishmarket there are four thousand people living on plank walkways and boat-houses on stilts and six rope bridges, in the one part of Purewater that armed men have never gone into, because horses are useless there and the locals know every roof. If that chain had come off the Baron's neck on the Temple steps in front of the whole city, they would have gone in at dawn with hooks, and they would have cut the bridges first, because cutting six rope bridges turns a neighbourhood into forty islands of frightened people who cannot reach each other.

None of that happened.

It did not happen because a debt collector in a hired skiff shook her head at a boy across twenty-five metres of water, and not one of those four thousand people will ever know it, and that is simply how it works.

The boy came up out of the Lady's water and stood there dripping and did not wipe his face and did not blink.

The priestess who had put him under took her hand off him early — a count or two early, where every other man on that stair had got the full measure and a bit over for being important — and stepped back off

the bottom step with her skirts dragging and looked up the terraces at the High Priestess, and waited to be told something.

Nerissa did not tell her anything. Nerissa said the words over the boy from where she stood, in the same voice she had used all morning, and the white rods moved the next house down.

The Baron already had his shirt on.

Kag watched the pair of them go up the green stone and thought about a chain with no clasp, and how you would get at a thing like that, and where a man like that ever stands still.

She had no idea at all.

She had, however, just watched four thousand people on a religious holiday, and every last one of them had been looking at somebody else.

CHAPTER 10 — HE BEGS



GARDWEN HAD BEEN IN THE TREES, and she had watched them take him, and she had not come out — and everything she had done in the ten years since had been an argument with that one night, conducted alone, in the open, in weather, against a version of herself who was nine years old and would not accept any of it.

She had buried the steading. She had spoken the rites over people she had known her whole life and could no longer recognise. She had walked out of the deep woods at seventeen with a wolf who chose her and a conviction that everybody she met treated as a kindness they were not going to argue with, which was that her brother had survived, and was alive, and was somewhere, and was seven.

And on Wednesday afternoon, on a competitors' ground in a city built on water, a boy had been walked out in harness and the helm had come off for four seconds and she had been right for ten years and it had not helped at all.

That was the part nobody warns you about either. Being right is not the same as getting him back. Being right is just the moment you stop having anywhere to put the hope.

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So on Thursday evening she went down to the seaward rocks at High Isle and took her boots off.

She set them side by side on a flat stone above the tideline and tied them together at the tops, the way you do at a bathing place, and she remembered doing it and thought it was a strange thing to be tidy about, and did it anyway.

Ruhi came to the edge of the water and stopped, because Ruhi had spent four years going everywhere and would not go there.

“Stay,” Gardwen said, which she had never once had to say to that animal.

The wolf sat down on the high rock with her forelegs braced and did not make a sound, and Gardwen went into the October sea off the north-east of a city with a hundred and forty tents of enemy eleven miles east of her, entirely alone, on the grounds that her brother was in a ship and nobody was doing anything about it.

She was, in her own considered opinion, a fucking idiot. She had thought so at the time. She went anyway.

*
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The cold takes your breath in a fist and then it takes your hands, in that order, and after about an hour it starts taking your judgement, which is the dangerous one.

She got to the stern chains and got her forearms over them and hung there in the dark under the counter of the Baron’s ship with the water going up and down her by a foot and a half, and she found the one piece of good fortune available that night, which was that the hull was *warm* down there, because the galley flue ran down the stern and the planking above the waterline had heat in it.

Warm planking carries sound.

And so a druid of the deep woods, hanging off a mooring chain in the sea with her lips going blue, put her ear against two inches of oak and listened to the most important quarter of an hour in the entire history of her family.

*
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He came down at about nine.

She knew it was him because the whole ship changed — the small noises of twenty people stopped for a moment, the way a house stops when the master comes in — and then there were boots on a companionway and a door, and then a voice.

And here is the thing she was not remotely prepared for.

He was *kind*.

That is the word. She used it twice when she finally told it and she never afterwards found a better one and she hated it every time. Baron Hanzo di Teufel went down below the waterline of his own ship to a boy he had stolen at seven years old, and he sat with him for a quarter of an hour, and he talked to him low and steady and gently, the way you settle a horse that has been frightened by weather. There was no cruelty in it anywhere. It would have been so much easier if there had been.

He said the boy's name. He said *Cailan*, out loud, more than once, which meant that somewhere in ten years he had bothered to keep it, which meant he had chosen to.

And then he said the other name, three times, and Gardwen got it wrong because of the water and the oak, but what she heard was *Thuban*.

And something answered him.

Not a seventeen-year-old. It was a grown man's voice and it came out of that chest wrong, the way a note comes out of a cracked bell, and what it was doing — underneath the Baron's voice, continuously, the entire quarter of an hour, never once stopping —

— was asking to be let go.

Not screaming. Not threatening. Asking. Over and over, patiently, the way a man in a cell asks for water, and the Baron talked gently across the top of it and did not acknowledge it even once, because he had been doing this every night for ten years and had long ago stopped hearing it.

Gardwen hung on a chain in the black sea and listened to her brother's body beg.

*
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She lost the last of it, which was the part about what would be wanted tomorrow, because the tide came up and she could not get her ear back onto the planking and her hands had stopped being hands.

That was when she slipped, and the chain rang.

Lanterns came out along the pier, four of them and then six. Men with boat-hooks going down into the water by the mooring chains. A light held over the side and walked the whole length of the hull, twice, and a voice giving orders that never once rose.

She went under the counter and stayed there for two hours in the cold with hooks going past her, holding on with her forearms because her fingers had finished, and thinking about absolutely nothing at all except the next breath, which is what the sea does to you and is, on balance, a mercy.

*
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And after he had gone, when it was just the water and the ship's timbers and the ordinary noise of a vessel at night — she heard the other thing.

Somebody in there was crying.

A boy. Not the other one. A boy, seventeen, on his own, in the dark, below a waterline, after his father had gone up the companionway and shut the door.

He was in there the whole time.

He had been in there the whole time, for ten years, listening to all of it.

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She did not remember the swim back and she did not remember the rocks.

What she remembered afterwards, and what she never told anybody except once, badly, on a wash-room floor, was the wolf coming down off the high rock in four jumps and going into the shallows to her chest and getting a mouthful of her shirt, and an enormous grey shape coming off the stones into the water to her thighs to take the rest of her weight, and somebody saying *I've got her*.

And then Magda — sixty-odd years old and a head and a half shorter than any of them — carrying her up Constantine's water steps herself, and refusing, with a flat and appalling calm, to give her to anybody else on the way.

They got her onto the wash-room floor with every blanket in the house and the firebox roaring, and Constantine did it slowly, because she had seen what hot does to men pulled out of the Mouth in February.

Magda sat on the boards with Gardwen's head on her thigh and rubbed her hands between her own, hard, the way you bring a lamb round, and said the entire time, in a completely level voice, that she was a bloody fool, and that she would be up in an hour, and that this was nothing.

She did not believe one word of it. Gardwen could hear that she did not.

It was better than an hour before the shaking started, which Constantine said was the good sign.

*
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She got hold of the half-orc's collar with a hand that could not grip and said it straight into her face, because it had to come out first, before the cold, before the names, before any of the rest of it.

"He *begs*."

A beat.

And then, when her mouth would work again, the rest — the quarter of an hour, the kindness, the voice out of the cracked bell, the boy crying on his own in the dark afterwards.

“He calls him by his name,” she said. “Cailan. He says it every night.”

She lay on her back on a wash-room floor with a wolf across her feet and her eyes shut and made the one deduction that none of the rest of them had got to, and made it out loud, slowly, because her mouth was still bad.

“If they take him — wherever he goes, the chain goes on him. In a cell, or a box in some clerk’s cupboard, or on a body. And there’s nobody holding the other end. And whatever that is in my brother has been asking to be let out for ten years.”

The firebox ticked.

“So it comes off first,” Gardwen said. “Then you can do whatever you like with him.”

CHAPTER 11 — A MAN WHO CANNOT BUY A FISH



BLAU HAD NOT BEEN FRIGHTENED OF ANYTHING SINCE HE WAS NINETEEN YEARS OLD, and he understood perfectly well that this was not courage — courage is a thing that costs you something every time you spend it — but an absence, burned out of him along with most of the left side of his face in a farmhouse that no longer existed, in a war that nobody in Purewater had ever heard of, on an afternoon he had stopped being able to remember the smell of about a decade ago and which he did not miss.

What the fire had actually taken was his belief that noise achieves anything.

Everybody else he had ever worked with shouted. Shouting was the whole industry. Shouting at the men, shouting at the locals, shouting at the boy who fetched the horses, shouting — God help them all — at Hanzo di Teufel, which was a thing four separate men had tried in nineteen years and which had worked precisely never. Blau did not shout and had not shouted since he was nineteen, and the effect of that on a household was extraordinary and had been quietly making him indispensable for two decades.

He was not loyal to the Baron. He wanted to be clear about that with himself, periodically, the way you check a knot.

He was loyal to finishing things.

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On the Friday morning he came ashore at half seven and discovered, standing on the Fishmarket bridge with a purse in his hand, that he could not buy a fish.

It was not a scene. That was the thing about it and he admired it, distantly, the way he admired most competent work. The woman behind the trestle weighed whiting for a man on his left, and finished, and started on somebody else, and the queue simply rearranged itself around him the way water goes round a post. Nobody refused him. Nobody looked at him. Two porters had stopped to watch and were pretending they had not.

He had been standing there ten minutes.

Behind him his two Knights were grey in the face, and one of them had his hand on the rail, and neither of them had eaten since Wednesday.

Blau ran the situation the way he ran everything, which was as a list of facts with no adjectives attached.

The young master had walked off his father's ship on Tuesday night after a child handed him a bundle at a landing, and had not come back. That was four days. The Baron did not yet know, because Blau had not told him, because telling him was what made a mess expensive, and because the version currently circulating in the taverns — that Lord Santo had ridden out of Purewater at midnight with a Pearl girl in his brother's coat, witnessed from two bridges by about sixty people who had no reason on earth to lie about it — was the most useful thing that had happened to Blau in a fortnight and he had no intention of disturbing it.

He was, he acknowledged, entirely prepared to believe it himself. The boy had done less plausible things.

What he was not prepared to do was leave a knife lying in a canal.

He had hired eight of them off that bridge on Wednesday, out of his own purse, and told each one they were the only one, which was a routine precaution and which had held for about four hours on the grounds that you cannot hire eight people off one bridge and have nobody notice. He knew that when he did it. The eight were not for information. The eight were to find out who came and bought them, and by Thursday evening he knew exactly who had — because six of his slates had started coming back with the same flavour of nothing on them, which is the signature of a professional, and there was only one of those in this city.

Crowbill. Fine. That told him what he needed, which was the shape of the thing he was standing in.

The dredgers were the part he was actually pleased with.

Ten sovereigns a boat, out of his own purse again, to every dredger on that water — *any canal, any depth, no questions asked or answered* — and a drawing of the blade done himself with a fine nib, because he had held that knife on four separate occasions and could draw it with his eyes shut. The Dredgers were Guild to nobody and answered to nobody, which meant Crowbill had never been able to buy them in thirty years and neither had anybody else, and Blau had walked in and bought all of them in a morning with money.

He did not care about the body. A body in this city is a problem for the person who put it there. He cared about eleven inches of barbed iron with his employer's *sigil on the pommel*, sitting in the mud of a canal or, far worse, in somebody's kitchen drawer — because a body is an accusation against one man and that knife is an accusation against a house.

Nineteen years of cleaning up after the young master, and the boy had managed, on his way out of the world, to leave behind the only object that could hang the family.

Blau had a certain professional respect for that. It was the most effective thing Santo di Teufel had ever done.

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The half-orc came over the bridge toward him at about twenty to eight and he watched her come the whole way.

Everybody else on that bridge had spent the morning being extremely apologetic at him. This one walked straight up, which meant she wanted something, which meant she was the first useful thing on this island in four days.

“I need to hire somebody in Purewater,” he said. “Nobody in Purewater will take my money.”

He turned his hands over, empty, which he did deliberately, because he had learned a long time ago that an empty hand is worth more than a threat to anybody who is any good.

“You’re the first person in two days who’s walked toward me. What will it cost?”

She told him she was Crowbill’s and that he was therefore talking to Crowbill, and Blau said *good* and meant it, because a man with a price is a considerably simpler proposition than a man with feelings.

And then he laid it out and watched her take it without a flicker.

Six boats. Tonight, after the closing, off High Isle’s seaward pier on the ebb, out through the Mouth and east along the coast — not up the Anminster road, which he did not explain and which she did not ask about. Twenty-two people and their gear. Cash on the stones before anything went aboard.

“And there’s one more thing that comes with us,” he said. “It goes in the bottom of a boat, it doesn’t get opened, and nobody puts a hand on it but me.”

In eleven minutes of talking on that bridge he did not once say *my lord*, or *the Baron*, or *di Teufel*, and he did not name anybody he worked for at all.

He noticed himself not doing it, afterwards, on the water, and turned it over for a while, and let it go.

*
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Here is what nobody in Purewater knew, and what Blau had told exactly no one in nineteen years, because telling is how people lose things.

He had watched Hanzo di Teufel seat a spirit in a living body eleven times.

He had held the lamp. He had carried the case. He had put the boy back in the hold afterwards and washed the floor, and he had stood four feet away for every step of it because somebody always has to be holding something, and he had no ear for the working whatsoever and had known that about himself since he was twenty. He could not have said one word of it if you put a knife in him.

But he knew the *order*. He knew what the boy looked like on the second morning as against the third. He knew the step that had to be done every single day at first light or the edges of the seat worked loose, because he had watched it done at first light every single day for ten years, in ports and in fields and once in the back of a moving wagon.

And the man who had that knowledge in his hands did not need to be a mage.

He needed a vessel, and a chain, and a boat.

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The bill came back at noon and it was the single most impressive thing Blau encountered in the whole of that miserable week, and he did not realise until much later that it had been built specifically to interrogate him.

It was itemised. Hulls, at forty-five the boat, because a boat that goes out past the bar at night with armed strangers in it may not come back and is therefore sold and not hired — which was correct, and which he had never seen a boatman have the nerve to write down. Polers at eight *the man*. Passage at four *the head*. One item carried in the bilge, not opened, at the contractor's risk, priced on its own,

because whoever wrote it had understood inside about four seconds that it was the only line he could not do without.

Six hundred, and he would have paid nine.

And the passage line said, in words, in a boy's flat recitation on a landing step: *twenty-two heads at four the head, every head the same rate, servant, soldier, and his lordship.*

Blau read that back three times in his head and felt something he had not felt in a very long time, which was mild, genuine amusement.

Four shillings. They had priced Hanzo di Teufel, Baron of Teufel, at four shillings and put him on a list between a cook and a sergeant.

He could have let it stand. He thought about letting it stand for perhaps two seconds, and then he corrected it, because he was a professional and a professional does not go out on a night tide with a manifest that says twenty-two when it says twenty-one, and because in nineteen years he had never once knowingly left a wrong number on a piece of paper.

"Agreed, the whole of it, six hundred, cash on the stones at dusk," he told the boy in the green cap. "And tell them one line's wrong. Twenty-one heads, not twenty-two." A beat. "And the item goes in the boat first, not last."

The boy said it back twice, which was good practice, and ran off north with it.

Blau watched him go and then went and stood at the end of the Guild landing for a while, looking at the water, at a city that would not sell him bread, which he was leaving tonight with everything that mattered in the bottom of a boat.

He had not eaten in two days himself. He had not really noticed.

It did not once occur to him — and this was the only genuine mistake he made all week, and it was the same mistake every single person in that city made about her — that the woman who had written him that bill had written it in order to *ask him a question*, and that he had just answered it.

CHAPTER 12 — AN ITEMISED BILL



KAG FOUND THE MAN WHO WAS FOLLOWING HER IN ABOUT A MINUTE, which was not a triumph of tradecraft on her part but an act of mercy on his, because he was two boats back and he had plainly never done this before in his life and he was trying extremely hard.

He changed ferries when she changed ferries. He got out at the Fishmarket steps and then could not think of a single reason to be at the Fishmarket steps, so he bought a fish he did not want and stood on the stones holding it.

It was Dess. Rope and cordage, third pitch along. Eleven shillings short on Monday because four of them had walked off with sixty feet of his best line.

She came up behind him and cleared her throat, and Dess went about four inches straight up and the fish went in the water.

“That was my dinner,” he said, and then shut his eyes.

It took ten seconds after that. A shilling a day and sixpence for anything written down, and he was to say where she went and who she spoke to and whether she went on the water at night, and he gave the whole thing up so fast and so completely that it was obvious he had been sick about it since noon.

“They gave me a slate,” Dess said, and produced a slate. There was nothing on it. “I didn’t know how to spell half orc.”

So she took the slate off him and wrote it out in a hand better than his and worse than a clerk’s.

Went Pearl about 3. Sylph’s Embrace. Big argument with the woman Constantine out in the street, heard by all. Left angry. Fishmarket. Ate. Did not go on the water.

Not one word of it was a lie. That was the trick of it, and it was a trick she had off nine years of debt collection: the very best lie you will ever tell is a true statement with the interesting bit taken out.

“There’s eight of us,” Dess said, when he had got his coat closed over it, and he said it without being asked, because he was talking now and could not stop. “He hired eight off this bridge out of his own purse and told every one of us we were the only one.”

“Where do the slates go?”

“Six o’clock. Under the third arch of the Gate of Triumph bridge, on the water. He doesn’t come himself.” Dess rubbed his thumb on the frame. “There’s a woman in a boat.”

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The woman in the boat was fifty-odd and built like the winch she was sitting next to, with cloth wound round her head and her boots off in October and a pipe that did not come out of her mouth for conversation, and she saw Kag coming a very long time before Kag arrived, because she had spent thirty-five years looking at water for a living and knowing what was in it that should not be.

She hauled the bucket up off its line and set it inside the gunwale, which meant no slates tonight, and then let Kag come the rest of the way in her own time.

“Say it out loud or clear off.”

Kag laughed at herself, which turned out to be the correct opening, and asked whether the woman knew her.

“Everybody on this water knows you. You’re Crowbill’s counting — big grey one, does the bridges on the Shoals, reads a book.” The pipe went round to the other side. “And you’re the one that stood on the Fishmarket bridge on Monday and told four of the Baron’s men to their faces they were thieves, in front of the whole market, and then walked up the steps.”

A beat.

“My sister’s boy was on that bridge. He’s told it nine hundred times and it gets better every time.”

Her name was Ossa Kyne and she did not do favours — she said so, plainly, twice, because favours make you part of a thing and she had spent thirty-five years not being part of things. Then she answered the question anyway, for her sister’s boy, which is how almost everything in that city actually gets done.

“He’s not looking for a man. Not once did he say a man, nor a body, nor a size, nor a night.” She came up with a folded square of paper out of an oilcloth. “He’s looking for a knife.”

It was a drawing. A single blade near enough to life size, done in ink with a fine nib, barbed along the back edge, and a mark near the hilt rendered with a great deal more care than the rest of it — every line of it separate, by somebody who knew that mark extremely well.

Underneath, in a small tidy hand: *any canal, any depth. Ten sovereigns. No questions asked or answered.*

“He gave one of those to every dredger on the water,” Ossa said.

Ten sovereigns was more than that woman made in a season, and there were eleven dredgers on that water, and the man had paid it out of his own purse in a city that would not sell him bread.

He is not frightened of a body, Kag thought, sitting in a skiff under a bridge in the dark with a drawing in her hand. *He is frightened of a knife.*

And the knife had never left the room.

That was the whole of it, and she had not done it out of cleverness. She had done it on Tuesday night because a debt collector knows that a thing in your hand is yours and a thing on a floor with a witness in the doorway belongs to the truth. She had turned it a quarter-turn with the back of her own knife and taken a rubbing and left it lying.

So on Friday evening, four nights on, it was still against the skirting on the third floor at the Sylph's Embrace — in a house the grey man had walked through that same afternoon, asking politely after a thirteen-year-old girl — with the blood gone from black and tacky to black and dry.

She took it out in a doubled linen off Constantine's press, tied at both ends with kitchen twine, laid in with the flat of her own blade so that no finger of hers went near the hooks.

And in the other hand she had the thing that was worth more, which was a house ledger written on the night, standing up, in a clear round hand, by the woman who owned the room.

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**

Temerach Nebulo was at the back corner table of the Moist Oyster with her back to the wall and a mail coat across her knees, going along the rings one at a time with a small tool, while down at the fire end Thorne told forty people about an elf who had put four arrows in the middle at two hundred paces that morning. It had been three arrows that morning. By Thursday it would be six and a gale.

The elf was ignoring all of it, which Kag liked her for immediately.

She put the tool down flat on the table, which from a woman who had not stopped for the whole of Thorne's performance was a considerable quantity of attention.

"Say the girl's name or don't, I don't need it yet. The scroll. How much of it is there, is it burnt, and how do you know the hand is his?"

Kag told her. Three pieces. Out of a grate. A grown man's fast practised hand, and the same figure drawn twice that was cut into the pommel.

"Who saw it come out of the grate besides you?"

Constantine. And it was in her house ledger, written that night, standing up, and she had offered to countersign it in daylight.

"And the mark on the knife?"

Orsk & Daughter, in the Forge Quarter. Hild's book, chained to the bench, four generations of it. Cut to a stranger's drawing on the fourth of June — four months before the column ever came down the Anminster road.

Something happened behind the elf's face and was gone before it could be named.

"Where is the knife now?"

"We've got it. You can have the lot of it if you ask."

And Temerach Nebulo, who had spent four years trying to get Hanzo di Teufel called to answer and had never once dared open her mouth about it, did not say yes.

"A Purewater thief walks into a tavern," she said, "and offers a King's officer the one thing she has wanted for four years, for nothing at all." Her eyes came up. "What do you want?"

"I want the fucker gone. He's a scourge on this city and I resent his men strutting about like they own the place."

The elf nodded once, because it matched what three separate people had told her about this woman before supper.

"Good. That I can work with. A man who wants paying I have to think about."

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At seven the next morning, in a shed on the water at the end of the founders' lane, two women who kept books established inside about

ninety seconds that they liked each other, and then went at it like a stocktake.

Constantine described a clerk's hand. Hild described a callus. Constantine said *ink on the middle finger, not the first*, and Hild said *that's a man who's held a pen fifty years*, and Temerach said almost nothing and wrote almost everything down in a small tight hand on paper she had brought with her.

Kag stood at the back by the quench tub with her arms folded and let the honest people work, and she was, on the whole, more uncomfortable there than she had been on the Lost Isle, and she did not examine that.

Then Hild put both hands flat on the bench and said no.

"I'll not swear a Baron bought it. A Baron didn't buy it. A Purewater man of about fifty-five bought it, with ink on his middle finger and the buttons cut off his coat so there'd be nothing on him to know him by, and he stood where you're stood and he was frightened the whole time he was in this shed."

She looked up.

"My great-grandfather started that book. Nobody has ever put a thing in it that wasn't so."

And Temerach Nebulo, who had not moved from the door in half an hour, let out a breath that was almost certainly relief.

"Good," she said. "That's the only kind of witness worth having."

A beat.

"Would you know him again?"

*
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Hild went to the back of the shed and was gone a while, and there was the sound of a chest, and she came back with a second book — smaller, unchained, the instrument book — and turned the pages with her thumb.

"I've made for him. Twice. A pair of calipers and a brass rule with a Guild stamp on the tang."

She turned it round.

"I never knew him in the shed in June because he wasn't in his coat. That's why he cut the buttons off." She tapped the page. "It's not the buttons. It's the *indigo*."

There was a name on the line, and a Guild, and the date was two years old, and the hand was Hild's own.

Ivo Calder. Tide Master, Watercrafters Guild. Assessor by appointment to the city of Purewater.

"That," said Constantine, to nobody in particular, "is the man who signed off the Lady's fouling as a false reading in the spring."

The bellows went next door and the whole shed breathed in, and four women stood round a bench in the Forge Quarter and understood, all at the same moment and none of them saying it, that whatever had come down the Anminster road nine weeks ago had been *invited*.

Kag went out into the founders' lane at eight in the morning with sixty workshops around her and a question she had no idea how to answer, which was how you get a closed ring of black iron off a living man's throat in a room full of people in about two seconds.

She was still standing there when Pell came round the corner at a dead run.

CHAPTER 13 — CROWBILL'S TOWN



KAG STOOD ON HIGH ISLE'S SEAWARD PIER AT DUSK IN THE OPEN with a lamp beside her and six hundred sovereigns about to be counted into her hands, and the single strangest thing about the most dangerous evening of her life was that she was not hiding from anybody, because she was the contractor, and the contractor stands where the contractor stands.

Hild had put a tool in her hand at six o'clock, black, no shine on it anywhere, made that afternoon at speed and tempered properly and fitted to her own palm off a string measurement taken across the bench. A little hooked thing with a hardened wheel and a flat tongue in front of the wheel. Four hundred years old, that idea, and it exists because old women's fingers swell and the ring has to come off and you cannot have it come off with the finger.

The tongue goes under, between the ring and the flesh, and the wheel rides on the tongue, and it cuts metal and it cannot cut meat, because there's steel in the way.

And: Three turns. Not two, and not until it feels right, because it never feels right, and men have stood there sawing at a thing for a minute and a half and been killed doing it.

Count them out loud if you have to, the dwarf had said.

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They came off the ship at twenty to seven and they came off *well*, which told Kag a great deal about who had actually been running that vessel for two days. No shouting. Bundles first, then people, in ones and twos, down the plank and along the stones in a line that did not bunch.

Twenty-one of them. She counted, because of course she counted.

Blau came down third and walked straight to her and counted six hundred into her hands in coin, on the stones, in front of his own people, and took his time over it, and did not ask her to count it after.

"Boats look right," he said.

The last thing off that ship came up out of the hold on ropes: a chest, near seven feet, rope beackets at both ends, and it took four of them and they struggled with it and it was very much heavier than a chest that size. It did not shift inside. It made no sound at all. The underside was wet and steaming faintly in the cold, because it had spent its whole life below a waterline.

Blau put both hands on it going down the plank and did not take them off until it was in the bilge of the second boat.

Kag's boat. Kag's man on the rope.

And a skiff went off the end of that pier like a man carrying a message about boats, and four minutes later a girl with a tray crossed a slope in the dark and offered a cup at a woman's elbow, and Mariarta of the Promise of Heaven put a copy of Kag's own handwriting into the hand of a mercenary captain who had been standing at the back of his own men for four days running, waiting to be told what was happening.

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Seven o'clock came and went, and five boats were loaded, and the sixth took the last four and their gear, and there was nothing on the path up from the terraces. Nothing at all. No lamp, no runner, no sound.

Blau came down the stones to the head of the line and put his hand on the second boat's gunwale, above the chest.

"Right," he said, not loudly, to the whole pier. "Cast off."

And Kag, who could not think of anything clever, put her head up and walked back along the stones with her hand raised, the way a person does when they have heard something over water.

"You've been paid," Blau said. He did not move off the gunwale. "You want me on these stones another ten minutes and I've no idea why, and I'd rather not find out on a falling tide."

He straightened up. "Cast off. All of them."

And then everybody else on that pier heard it too.

Boots on stone, up on the path from the terraces. One man, running, and running the way a man runs when he is not thinking about the ground at all. Then a second set and a third, a long way behind and losing.

Baron Hanzo di Teufel came off the path onto the pier at a dead run in the clothes he had stood in front of a Prince in an hour before. No harness, no sword, no household, one shoe gone somewhere on that hill, and he was fifty-one years old and he had run the better part of a mile.

He stopped dead at the head of the line.

He was not looking at Blau at all.

He was looking at the second boat, and the wet black chest lying in the bottom of it, with two of Crowbill's men either side holding water with their poles.

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"Take it out of the boat." His voice was wrecked from the running and it was not loud. "Put it back aboard, and I will not have heard any of this."

"No, my lord."

"..."

"You'd never have got him home." Blau had not moved. There was no relish in it and no apology either. "You've been telling him he was going home for ten years and the boy believes it, and you don't."

Twenty-one people sat in five boats and did not move and did not say one word, because they were his household and he was still their Baron, and not one of them had worked out which way this went.

Blau got out of the boat and put himself on the stones between the two of them and put a hand flat on the Baron's chest, and Hanzo walked into it and stopped.

And then he looked past Blau's shoulder at the chest, and said a name.

Not loudly. Low and steady and kind — the exact voice Gardwen had described through two inches of oak, the voice you use on a horse — and it carried the whole length of that pier because every other sound on it had stopped.

"Thuban."

The chest moved.

Once. A single heavy shift, like something settling, and the boat under it dipped and came back and the water slapped along the stones, and both of Crowbill's men in that boat were suddenly holding their poles very badly indeed.

He said it again, and added three words in a language that put the hair up on Kag's arms.

And something inside seven feet of wet oak took hold of the lid from underneath.

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She went round the outside of the lamps with the tool already in her left hand and the thumb loop on, and the Baron of Teufel saw her coming and dismissed her.

His eyes came off the chest and went over her once — the size, the leather, the club, the lamp behind — and went straight back to the boat.

A dock half-orc, moving on a dock. He did not have room in his head that night for whatever she was, and he never had had, and neither had anybody else in thirty years, and it was the first time in her entire life that it had been worth anything at all.

Three steps and she was on him.

Her left hand went inside the open collar and her fingers got under the ring — and there was the slack, half a finger's worth, where nine weeks of this city had taken the flesh off him — and she hauled it up off the skin and held it there, and he came back against her like a sack, because he was fifty-one and he had just run a mile.

The tongue went under. Steel between iron and throat, exactly as the dwarf had said.

One. Two. Three.

And the ring did not part.

What it did was bite. A bright notch cut in the black iron the width of a fingernail, silver in the lamplight, and the wheel sitting in the bottom of it, and the ring still a ring.

Down the pier Blau turned round. In the boat the lid of the chest lifted three inches and stopped, held from underneath.

And the Baron, hanging off her left hand with his windpipe half shut, got both arms up in front of him and began to say something that was not in any language ever spoken on that water.

She tried to get her head into the back of his skull and could not do it past her own arm.

He finished the words.

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Everything stopped except her eyes and her ears.

Her left fist was inside his collar with the ring hauled up off his throat and her right thumb was through the loop with the wheel in its notch, and that is where they stayed, and they were not going

anywhere, and neither was she. The shout she had been going to make got as far as the back of her teeth and stopped there.

Out on the black water somebody said one quiet word and nothing whatsoever happened to him. He did not even turn his head towards it.

And then four crossbows went off out of the dark at about nine feet.

They fired because Crowbill had given four men one instruction on Thursday afternoon — *not unless a man starts casting, and then until he stops* — and because Crowbill's people do exactly what Crowbill said, which is the entire reason he had lasted thirty years and the entire reason it had been no use to her ten seconds earlier.

Two of them found him. Both of them found the same place.

Hanzo di Teufel stopped being a man in the middle of a word. He went down instantly and completely and straight down, and he did not fall away from her, because her fist was shut in his collar, so he hung there off her frozen arm with his whole weight on her knuckles and his chin on her wrist.

The ring was six inches under her eyes with one bright notch in it.

She could not turn the wheel. She could not let go. She could not say a word.

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The skiff came in out of the dark on the seaward side without a lamp, close enough that the ship's two lights picked it up, and a figure in a plain coat stood up in the stern in front of twenty-one people, Blau, six boat crews and whatever was standing in the second boat.

Three words, and a hand cut sideways through the air.

Hesper had spent an entire career being nobody, on the settled understanding that a described intelligencer is a dead one, and they broke that in front of twenty-six witnesses for a half-orc they had known for four days, and then sat back down and let the boat back away as though nothing had occurred.

It went out of Kag all at once and it was horrible, and she and the Baron of Teufel went down onto the wet stone together in a heap with her fist still shut in his collar.

She got a knee under her.

Three turns.

On the third the wheel went through and the notch became a gap, and the ring *sprang* — sprang, like a thing that had been under tension for ten years — and the two cut ends jumped apart under her thumb and it came off the dead man's throat into her left hand.

There was a locket on it the size of a thumbnail.

It was warm. It was very much warmer than anything else on that pier.

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Above her, the thing standing in the wet shift made a sound.

Not a cry and not a word. Something going out of a chest, all of it, the way a man breathes out at the end of a very long day, and it went on a great deal longer than any lungs that size had any business holding.

And then the grown man's voice said one thing, and it was not to the pier and not to the dead man and not to anybody who had ever been afraid of it.

"Hold him. He'll not know how to stand."

Ten years a prisoner in somebody else's bones, begging every night to be let out, and the last thing Thuban Eta did on his way out of the world was worry about the boy.

The boy folded.

Kag got an arm up and took about half of him and he came down across her knees on the stones, seventeen years old and eight stone of nothing, and his eyes were open and moving and he was looking

at the lamps and the boats and the sky like somebody who had never seen any of it in his life.

He made a noise. It was a boy's noise.

And behind her on the stones Gardwen came apart entirely, and Magda let her go, and the woman from the woods got there on her hands and knees.

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Nobody in those boats drew a blade. There was not one sword out on that water.

Twenty-one people sat in five boats with everything they owned under the thwarts on a running ebb, forty feet off a pier, and the poles were in Purewater hands, and not a single one of them could crew anything. Two were standing. One of those was being sick over the side. An older man in the third boat had taken his hat off, and nobody had told him to.

They were waiting to be told what they were now, because the man who told them that was face down under Kag's knee with the back of his head opened up, and the man who was going to tell them next was standing eleven feet away and had not said anything for a minute and a half.

Blau came down the stones. He was not looking at his Baron and he was not looking at the boy.

"That," he said, "is mine."

"Since when, you cold-faced bastard?"

"Since he was forty-four and I was nineteen." He put his hands behind his back, which was somehow worse than reaching for something. "I have watched that man seat a spirit in a living body eleven times, and I have carried that locket in my own hand while he slept. There is not another person on this earth who knows what you are holding."

A beat.

“And you are going to need to know, tonight, because that boy is not finished.”

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He sold it for a boat, a man on the pole, and the sea, and he did not ask for the locket, and he did not haggle, and he put his own hands out to be tied.

What he gave for nothing, because they would have found it out by Thursday and Thursday would have been too late, was this: a seat ten years deep is a hole cut in a person, and it does not close because the tenant has walked out of it, and there is a step that was done at first light every single morning for ten years to keep the edges of it from working loose.

Nobody was going to do that on Wednesday.

Four mornings. That was the clock now.

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They brought the Baron up wrapped in a boat sail and he weighed almost nothing at all, which was the last thing Kag ever learned about Hanzo di Teufel.

Crowbill came down to the water himself, which he had not done once all week. He looked at the sail, and at the man tied in the bottom of the boat, and at the black ring lying open in her palm with the small warm thing on it, and at a seventeen-year-old asleep against his sister under Magda's coat.

“Right,” he said.

The body went into the ice-house on the stone under sacking, because the run goes out over the bar at four every morning of the year, and both di Teufels would leave Purewater the same way inside two days and neither of them would ever be found.

He took the six hundred off her and counted it, and then put two of every five back into her hands without a word, which he had never once done in front of witnesses.

And at the top of the steps he stopped.

“They heard you on that pier. Twenty-six people, and five of them were mine, and mine will tell it.”

This is Crowbill’s fucking town. She had said it out loud, in the dark, standing over a dead nobleman with a cut ring in her fist, to twenty-one people in boats who had nowhere on earth to go.

He almost smiled.

“Go and sleep, Kag. You’ll be hearing that one back off strangers by Friday.”

She went home over four bridges in the dark and did not meet one person who knew her name, and every single one of them stepped out of her way, the way they always had.

They had been doing it for thirty years because she was seven feet tall.

They would go on doing it now for entirely different reasons, and it was going to take her about a month to notice, and rather longer than that to decide whether she minded.